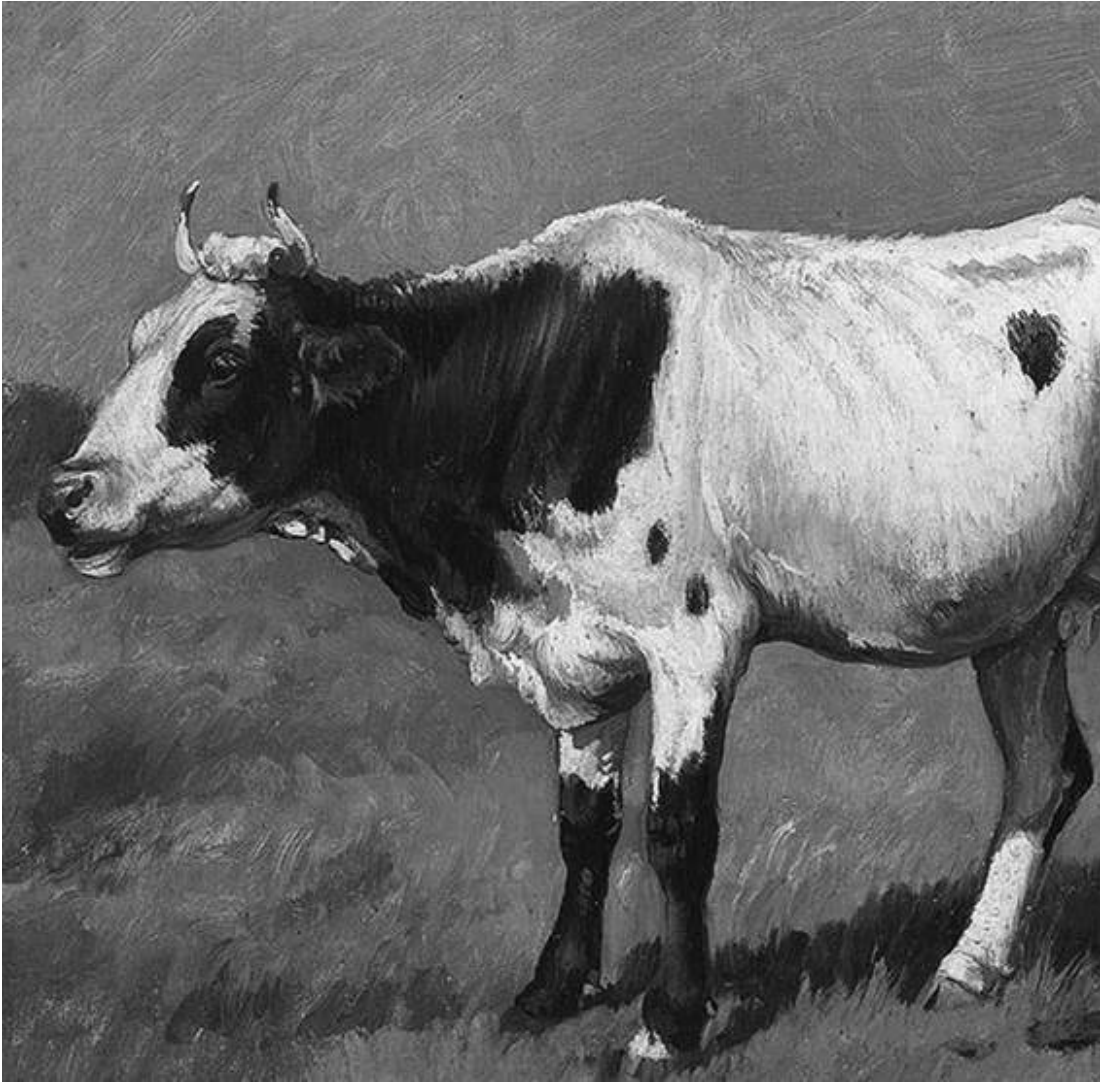


## Knowledge: justified true belief?



The difference between the rationalist and empiricist schools rested primarily on the way in which they believed we acquire knowledge – but what exactly *is* knowledge? The definition established by the classical Greeks is that it is ‘justified true belief’ – something becomes knowledge when three conditions are met: I believe it, it is factually true and I have verifiable justification for believing it. In the 1960s, however, Edmund Gettier showed that these conditions are not enough. Suppose a farmer is worried his cow is missing. A friend assures him that he has seen the cow in the field, so the farmer goes to check and sees the black-and-white shape of

his cow. The friend also checks, but finds the cow hidden in some trees and a large piece of black-and-white paper in the field, so he realises the farmer mistook the paper for the cow. The farmer *believes* the cow was in the field, it is *factually true* that it is and he is *justified* in the belief by the testimony of his friend – but in this case, is it right to say that he *knows* that it is?